

SETTING THE TONE
Prime Minister Narendra Modi announcing the Delhi Declaration, Sept. 9

Before the G20 summit in New Delhi began, there was, as Shakespeare put it, a tide in the affairs of men. The global order lay fractured. Divided by the Ukraine War. Split over how to tackle the adverse impact of climate change. Torn asunder by a pandemic that ravaged lives and economies. Disunited on how to conduct world trade. Bisected by the tech haves and have-nots. Dissected into income groups and development indices. The cleavages were deep and glaringly stark. But amidst all this gloom and doom, the most powerful grouping of world leaders had a choice. To paraphrase the Bard, taken at the flood, it could pull the world towards harmony, healing, hope and prosperity. If not, then with the Russian president Vladimir Putin and his Chinese counterpart Xi Jinping deciding to skip the summit, the Indian presidency of the G20 would have faced the grave prospect of omitting a consensus declaration from the leaders. That would have signalled a failure and cheered India's detractors but led to greater global strife and misery.

It would be India's moment, though, when Prime Minister Narendra Modi interrupted the proceedings of the G20 to announce dramatically that the New Delhi Declaration had the approval of its members. Banging down the gavel decisively, he declared that it had been adopted, to cheers not just from Team India that had worked hard to achieve it but also the assembled world leaders. If there was ever a turning point in recent history, then the one witnessed in the Bharat Mandapam on the afternoon of September 9, 2023 would be among the top contenders. For over 100 nations (including the African Union that was admitted to the G20 earlier that morning, thanks to India's persistence) that accounted for three-fourths of the world's GDP demonstrated they could sink their enormous differences and together work for the "global public good".

This was truly a 'woke' G20. Everyone agreed that war, including the one in Ukraine, caused "immense human suffering" and must be ended, as the New Delhi Declaration stated, but there were many more pressing concerns, including tackling global recession, lifting millions of people who had slipped below the poverty line after Covid's devastating impact apart from arresting the alarming and relentless march of climate change that was threatening humanity's very existence. Indian negotiators and their allies hammered home the point that the consequences of even a year of continuing anarchy and vacillation resulting from a lack of consensus in the G20 would be akin to the outbreak of World War 3. Amitabh Kant, India's Sherpa for the G20, who led the negotiations, said, "We told the members that instead of the warpath, the G20 should focus on the economic growth path, which was why it was formed in the first place. It cannot be preoccupied with the Ukraine war and bring the world to a standstill. Now 80 per cent of the global growth was coming from the emerging economies, including India, and six of the 12 fastest-growing economies in the world are in the Global South. So the G20 must prioritise their concerns." But the consensus on Ukraine came about primarily because of PM Modi's personal interactions with key G20 leaders not just in Delhi but also when he attended the BRICS summit in Johannesburg and the East Asia meet in Jakarta just prior to the Delhi summit.

The Delhi Declaration was a win-win for India and the world for several reasons. For one, by admitting the African Union, which has 55 members, it made G20 far more inclusive, apart from acknowledging the growing sa-



"INDIA TOLD THE WORLD THAT INSTEAD OF THE WARPATH IT SHOULD GO ON THE GROWTH PATH. THIS G20 BROUGHT MULTILATERALISM TO CENTRE STAGE"

AMITABH KANT
India's G20 Sherpa